

Trilateral Open Skies II: Rebuilding Transparency

Team Echo: Anthony Carrillo, Jacob Democko,
Yoon Roh, Saffiya Sheikh

Berkeley Public Policy / Nuclear

Engineering C285

May 2026

UC Berkeley



Main Questions:

- How do U.S. perceptions of topics like **warfare**, **nuclear use**, **deterrence**, **stability**, and the **spectrum of conflict** compare to those of its competitors?
- What **risks** arise in the differences among these perspectives?

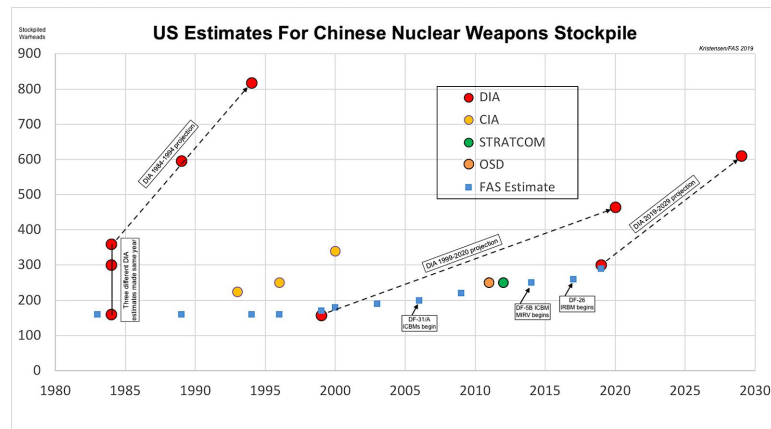
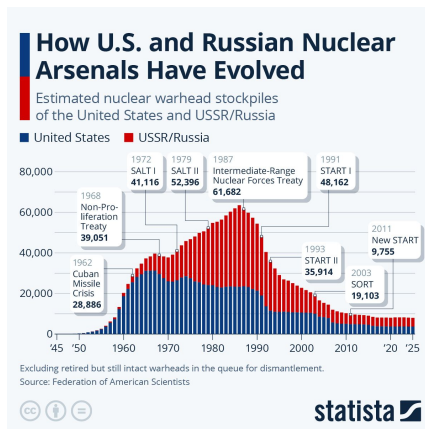
The Strategic Crisis of 2026

Treaty Collapse

The expiration of New START in 2026 marks the end of bilateral nuclear transparency. Status quo is characterized by minimal communication.

Qualitative Arms Race

Nuclear modernization has shifted from quantitative to qualitative, emphasizing low-yield tactical weapons and layered missile defense.



Diverging Strategic Doctrines



United States

Shifting from bilateral limits to trilateral concerns; modernizing for credible deterrence against two peers.



China

Rapid expansion for secure second-strike capability; shift away from strict "no-first-use" policy.



Russia

Doctrinal revisions authorizing use against non-nuclear threats; "siege mentality" regarding sovereignty; Ukrainian War

"The inadequacies of the unilateral constraints imposed on the United States under New START are most critically compounded by the emergence of a third major nuclear weapons power. China has said that its nuclear policy has been the most consistent in the world. That may have been true in the past, but is not true today." - Thomas DiNanno, US Under Secretary of State for Arms Control

Where are We Coming From?

Treaty on Open Skies (OST)



+



+

32 NATIONS

Entered Force: January 1, 2002

US Withdrawal: Nov 22, 2020 | **Russia Exit:** Dec 2021

1,500+

Total Flyovers

Unarmed observation
flights completed since
inception.

72

Hour

Advanced notice required
before flyover

42

Annual Quota

Max flights
allowed/received by US
and Russia each year.

New Strategic Arms Reduction Treaty



+



Entered Force: February 5, 2011

Sunset Expiration: February 5, 2026

1,550

Strategic Warheads

Max deployed warheads
on ICBMs, SLBMs, and
bombers.

700

Delivery Systems

Limit on deployed
strategic delivery vehicles.

800

Total Launchers

Deployed and
non-deployed launchers
allowed.

The Problem: Diverging Perspectives

“Each country’s apparent position on pursuing new arms-control agreements is untenable or unacceptable in the eyes of one or both of the other two,” (iiss, 2024)

Incompatible Strategic Lenses Leads to High-Stakes Decisions on Bad Data

Currently no official shared verification mechanisms to settle disputes.

- Policymakers increasingly rely on incomplete or disputed information, raising the likelihood of arms racing or crisis escalation.

UC Berkeley



Illustrative Case: China's Alleged Nuclear Tests (Feb 6, 2026)

- The U.S. released seismology data from 2020 to accuse China of undisclosed nuclear tests.
- First direct U.S-China accusation of CTBT violation (Liang, 2026)

H.S.S

**A dangerous trust gap persists
without diplomatic channels
(FDD, 2026)**

Proposed Policy: Open Skies II

Open Skies II is a trilateral data-sharing agreement involving China, the USA, and Russia.

It balances *feasibility* with *verifiability* for generating shared, treaty-governed data.



Reciprocal Flyovers

Regularized aerial observation of nuclear-related sites across all three parties' territories.

Shared Evidentiary Baseline

Reduces disputes about "what is really happening," lowering odds that routine exercises are misread as nuclear preparations.

Standardized Data Sharing

Certified, treaty-governed imagery available equally to all parties with no need to expose intelligence sources.

Evaluation of Policy Approaches

Approach	Viability	Verifiability	Reduce Misperceptions
Open Skies II	Probable	Highly Probable	Probable
Arms Control Treaty	Unlikely - China & US Hardline	Probable	Highly Probable
Track Two	Probable	Highly Unlikely	Probable
Open Skies I	Highly Unlikely	Probable	Probable
Status Quo	Highly Probable	Unlikely	Highly Unlikely

The Open Skies II Framework

Restoring Transparency

- Restores information parity without requiring immediate arsenal reductions.
- Institutionalizes reciprocal aerial observation and standardized data sharing.
- Creates structured diplomatic channels amidst distrust.



Why Open Skies II?



Open Skies I — Open Skies II

- China was never a signatory to Open Skies I
- War in Ukraine makes Russia less likely to share information on conventional force disposition with European countries
- Open Skies I: primary goal of general military transparency
- Open Skies II: nuclear treaty verification
- Implementation of new sensing technology

Summary of Current Policies

Decision Matrix			
	Viability	Verifiability	Reduce Misperceptions
Arms Control Treaty	Unlikely China is hardline against limitations. The U.S. is hardline against bilateral agreements.	Probable Verification mechanisms exist and were implemented in prior treaties. Limited by treaty language and meeting obligations.	Highly Probable Official government negotiations are legally binding
Track Two	Probable U.S.–Chinese track two dialogues in place. U.S.–Russia Track Two meetings held by Stimson and NCAFP.	Extremely Unlikely Unofficial dialogue does not automatically force government action.	Probable Establishes more channels of communication.
Status Quo	Highly Probable No cooperation mechanism is in place, requiring the least effort.	Unlikely States are not able to verify and compare intelligence without exposing sources and methods.	Highly Unlikely Without shared data or verification, states' information is limited and disrupted.

Key Implementing Bodies

United States

State Department
Bureau of Arms Control +
Defense Threat
Reduction Agency (DTRA
- Open Skies Division)



China

Ministry of Foreign
Affairs + PLS Air Force



Russia

Ministry of Foreign Affairs
+ Ministry of Defense



Multilateral

Open Skies Consultative
Commission
(consensus-based
secretariat)



Roadblocks & Implementation



Shared Technical Obstacles

- U.S. and Russian Open Skies aircraft are outdated and need recertification.
- Triad must agree on a common aircraft for Chinese overflight.
- Cost-sharing for infrastructure and communication systems.
- OSCC consensus rule allows any single state to block procedural changes.
- Establishing a new Open Skies while disregarding still-participating European states may also generate political pushback.

Conclusion: A Pragmatic Path Forward



Open Skies II is a politically feasible way to rebuild nuclear transparency without demanding immediate arsenal cuts.

Reduces Misperception

Standardized, shareable imagery limits contested intelligence narratives across the U.S.–Russia–China triad

Leverages Precedent

Builds on existing Open Skies technical and institutional infrastructure, tailored to each great power's concerns

Keeps the Door Open

A limited confidence-building measure — not a disarmament bargain — that slows escalatory dynamics and enables more ambitious agreements in the future

Questions?

Trilateral Open Skies II: Rebuilding
Transparency

Berkeley Public Policy / Nuclear Engineering C285

May 2026



References

A new nuclear arms race looms. (n.d.). *The Economist*. Retrieved April 18, 2026, from

<https://www.economist.com/international/2023/08/29/a-new-nuclear-arms-race-looks>

Arms Control Association. (2022, April). *The treaty on Open Skies at a glance*. <https://www.armscontrol.org/factsheets/openskies>

Bell, A., & Wier, A. (2019). Open Skies Treaty's quiet legacy under threat. *Arms Control Today*.

<https://www.armscontrol.org/act/2019-01/features/open-skies-treaty-quiet-legacy-under-threat>

Budryk, Z. (2020, November). *China: US withdrawal from Open Skies treaty undermines trust*. The Hill.

<https://thehill.com/policy/international/russia/527139-china-us-withdrawal-from-open-skies-treaty-undermines-trust/>

Carnegie Endowment for International Peace. (2024, July). *Strategic change in U.S. foreign policy*.

<https://carnegieendowment.org/research/2024/07/strategic-change-us-foreign-policy>

Chen, D. (2026). Goodbye New START: How China's rise ended nuclear arms control. *The Diplomat*.

<https://thediplomat.com/2026/01/goodbye-new-start-how-chinas-rise-ended-nuclear-arms-control/>

Congressional Research Service. (2025). *The U.S. withdrawal from the Open Skies treaty* (No. IF11662).

https://www.congress.gov/crs_external_products/IF/HTML/IF11662.html

Finnish Institute of International Affairs. (2020). *Turbulence in arms control*. <https://fiia.fi/en/publication/turbulence-in-arms-control>

Foundation for Defense of Democracies. (2026, February). *China denies U.S. accusation of nuclear tests*.

<https://www.fdd.org/analysis/2026/02/09/china-denies-u-s-accusation-of-nuclear-tests/>

Gavin, F. J. (2025). *Thinking historically: A guide to statecraft and strategy*. Yale University Press. <https://doi.org/10.12987/9780300285888>

Global Times. (2026). China expresses regret over expiration of New START treaty between Russia and the US: FM spokesperson. *Global Times*.

<https://www.globaltimes.cn/page/202602/1354866.shtml>

Goldgeier, J. (2024). *Why NATO and Ukraine are a flash point with Russia 30 years after the end of the Cold War*. PBS NewsHour.

<https://www.pbs.org/newshour/world/why-nato-and-ukraine-are-a-flash-point-with-russia-30-after-the-end-of-the-cold-war>

Hawkins, W. (2021, May). *US tells Russia it won't rejoin Open Skies treaty*. Courthouse News Service.

<https://www.courhousenews.com/us-tells-russia-it-wont-rejoin-open-skies-treaty/>

Jenkins, B. L. (2026, February). *Statement to the conference on disarmament*. U.S. Department of State.

<https://www.state.gov/releases/under-secretary-for-arms-control-and-international-security-affairs/2026/02/statement-to-the-conference-on-disarmament>

Kimball, D. G. (2024). Russia revises nuclear use doctrine. *Arms Control Today*. <https://www.armscontrol.org/act/2024-12/news/russia-revises-nuclear-use-doctrine>

Korda, M. (2022). Deterring Russian nuclear threats with low-yield nukes may encourage limited nuclear war. *Journal of Advanced Military Studies*.

<https://www.usmcu.edu/Outreach/Marine-Corps-University-Press/MCU-Journal/Journal-of-Advanced-Military-Studies-SI-2022/Deterring-Russian-Nuclear-Threats-with-Low-Yield-Nukes-May-Encourage-Limited-Nuclear-War/>

Licklider, R. E. (1970). The missile gap controversy. *Political Science Quarterly*, 85(4), 600–615.

Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People's Republic of China. (2025, November). *China releases white paper on arms control in new era*.

http://www.fmprc.gov.cn/mfa_eng/xw/wjbxw/202511/20251127_11761653.html

NATO. (2025). *Arms control, disarmament and non-proliferation in NATO*. <https://www.nato.int/en/what-we-do/wider-activities/arms-control-disarmament-and-non-proliferation>

Nuclear risks grow as new arms race looms—New SIPRI Yearbook out now | SIPRI (2025, June 16).

<https://www.sipri.org/media/press-release/2025/nuclear-risks-grow-new-arms-race-looks-new-sipri-yearbook-out-now>

Nuclear Threat Initiative. (2020). *Treaty on Open Skies*. <https://www.nti.org/education-center/treaties-and-regimes/treaty-on-open-skies/>

O'Hanlon, M. E. (2023, November 13). Don't expect Xi to restore the US-China military hotline this week. *Brookings*.

<https://www.brookings.edu/articles/dont-expect-xi-to-restore-the-us-china-military-hotline-this-week/>

Organization for Security and Co-operation in Europe. (2002). *Treaty on Open Skies*. <https://www.osce.org/node/108324>

Pan, Z. (2018). A study of China's no-first-use policy on nuclear weapons. *Journal for Peace and Nuclear Disarmament*, 1(1), 115–136. <https://doi.org/10.1080/25751654.2018.1458415>

Pentagon Says Chinese Nuclear Arsenal Still Growing | Arms Control Association. (n.d.). Retrieved April 21, 2026, from

<https://www.armscontrol.org/act/2025-01/news/pentagon-says-chinese-nuclear-arsenal-still-growing>

Reuters. (2026, February). *China says expiration of US–Russia arms treaty 'regrettable'*.

<https://www.reuters.com/world/china/china-says-expiration-us-russia-arms-treaty-regrettable-2026-02-05/>

Schneider, M. B. (2025). The implications of Russia's new nuclear doctrine. *National Institute for Public Policy Information Series*, (615).

https://nipp.org/information_series/mark-b-schneider-the-implications-of-russias-new-nuclear-doctrine-no-615-february-5-2025/

Sokov, N., & Woolf, S. (2024). *Evaluating current arms control proposals: Perspectives from the US, Russia, and China*. International Institute for Strategic Studies.

<https://www.iiss.org/research-paper/2024/10/evaluating-current-arms-control-proposals-perspectives-from-the-us-russia-and-china/>

Sälthane, H., & Taylor, M. (n.d.). *The Dynamics of an Entangled Security Dilemma*.

The Growing Push to Halt and Reverse the New Nuclear Arms Race | Arms Control Association. (n.d.). Retrieved April 18, 2026, from

<https://www.armscontrol.org/issue-briefs/2026-02/growing-push-halt-and-reverse-new-nuclear-arms-race>

Thielmann, G. (2011). The missile gap myth and its progeny. *Arms Control Today*, 41(4). <https://www.armscontrol.org/act/2011-05/missile-gap-myth-and-its-progeny>

U.S. Department of Defense. (2024). *Military and security developments involving the people's republic of China 2024: Annual report to congress*.

<https://media.defense.gov/2024/Dec/18/2003615520/-1/-1/1/MILITARY-AND-SECURITY-DEVELOPMENTS-INVOLVING-THE-PEOPLES-REPUBLIC-OF-CHINA-2024.PDF>

U.S. Department of State. (2020). *United states withdrawal from the treaty on Open Skies*. <https://2017-2021.state.gov/united-states-withdrawal-from-the-treaty-on-open-skies/>

U.S. Senate Committee on Foreign Relations. (2024, May). *The future of arms control and deterrence*.

<https://www.foreign.senate.gov/imo/media/doc/19047b26-4765-4204-2717-765e190cf88605%2015%2024%20-%20The%20Future%20of%20Arms%20Control%20and%20Deterrence.pdf>

Zhang, H. (2001). *A discussion on China's nuclear transparency options*. Belfer Center for Science and International Affairs.

<https://www.belfercenter.org/publication/discussion-chinas-nuclear-transparency-options>